

Change your mind

As you have already seen from the cover, we're starting 2016 by looking forward, but not with a what to expect this year story, but a what to expect this decade (or more) story.

Based on what we know of our readers, although spread across the age groups of 8 to 80, the majority of you are what most would consider to be "youth" (under 25). For all practical purposes you are the future of this nation, and perhaps the world.

Since we're starting the new year with telling you what technologies and ideas will disrupt our future, I suppose it makes sense for me to go the other way and tell warn you of one very real threat to true innovation. A dangerous but usually unnoticed trait in all of us, which makes us hang on to the past, clinging to it for dear life, looking for something familiar in this sea of newness. I don't know what to call it, so let's just go with intellectual inertia.

So what do I mean when I say inertia? You know when something is familiar, and you've gotten used to it? You feel like it's the best thing ever, to have that familiarity. When change does come along, it has to drag you forwards kicking and screaming sometimes, because you just love the old way of doing things.

Let me try and illustrate this further with examples.

Gmail may seem to be the way email always was to many of us. The conversation view, the labels... it's all so... so... perfect! Some would beg to disagree. There are many people who still prefer the old Microsoft Outlook way of showing and working with email. There are many who still refuse to give it up. Obviously as a person who prefers Gmail, I tend to look at them as suffering from inertia. There are many who will say, "Email? Who uses that anymore?" and accuse me of intellectual inertia.

Newer isn't always better, however. Take Windows 8 as the next example. Perhaps on the tablets that it was designed for, the interface was good. However for someone using the good old mouse and keyboard, being forced to use a tablet interface felt like Microsoft had gone bananas! I'm still on Windows 7, because I tried upgrading to Windows 10, and it started crashing randomly. Thankfully I was able to downgrade easily. However, Windows 8 I avoided like the plague on the desktop.

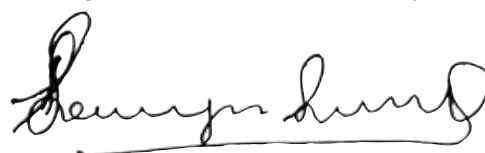
Microsoft actually may have been suffering from such inertia for a lot longer. I remember Bill Gates launching a Tablet PC way before Apple even dreamt of the iPad. The main reason why Microsoft's tablets bombed? Intellectual inertia. That was the time they did the reverse of the Windows 7 and 8 fiasco. They took an OS developed for a mouse and keyboard, and tried to force it on to a tablet. In hindsight, when you compare Windows XP Tablet edition to iOS, we know why the former failed...

Now, however, I think everyone is making the same mistake again, by trying to use a touch interface for everything. With the Internet of Things being so widely hyped, everyone wants to build connected devices with touch interfaces. Even stupid things like printers have tiny touch screens, when they're not needed. Perhaps you can understand why the manufacturers are adding them... you have to admit that you think a printer with a touch screen just looks a lot cooler than one with buttons. That's mental inertia at work, not just on the manufacturer's side, it's inside us as well.

Some car entertainment systems are going all touch screen. It's ridiculous. How is it we realise that poking at a touch screen phone to type a message is very dangerous when driving, as it distracts you from the road, and then have a touchscreen interface for a car that rivals a smartphone's complexity. Of course drivers shouldn't be fiddling with settings when driving... but then again we also know that driver's shouldn't be texting when driving, and yet they do both...

What we really need is to get over this inertia, break the molds, and give every new interface a try. I think the days of touch are numbered (you can read more about that in the cover story), but we're not going to let it die out as easily as we should, because of inertia from both manufacturers as well as users.

As more and more of you become makers, start influencing technology, founding startups, developing tech for big companies, or even just being a consumer like I am, I hope this little column will leave enough of an impression on you to overcome the inertia, be more accepting of change, and move forward more freely. 🇮🇳




Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
robert@digit.in

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